

Order Passeriformes continued

Family Rhipiduridae

Fantails

Length 5½–7½ in (14–19 cm)
Species 50



Named for their habit of fanning their long tails, these birds belong to the genus *Rhipidura*. They range from the Himalayas in the west to Australasia and the southwest Pacific Islands in the east, and are fiercely territorial. Fantails snatch flying insects with their small, but broad, bills and are very agile when on the wing.



NEW ZEALAND FANTAIL
Found in New Zealand and satellite islands—such as Chatham Island and Lord Howe Island—Rhipidura fuliginosa measures 5½–6½ in (14–17 cm) long. It builds a neat cuplike nest in a tree fork.

Family Vireonidae

Vireos and relatives

Length 6½–8 in (17–20 cm)
Species 63



The unusual name “vireo” is derived from a Latin word that translates as “to be green.” Birds in this family, which includes greenlets, shrike-vireos, and pepper shrikes, weigh from 1½ oz (9 g)



RED-EYED VIREO
About 6 in (15 cm) in length, Vireo olivaceus lives in deciduous forest in North America, and migrates to South America in winter.

to 7⁄8 oz (25 g). Their characteristically notched bills are larger than those of the New World warblers (see p.369), the eye-stripes bolder, and the green plumage duller. These birds inhabit broadleaved or mixed forests, and species coexist by foraging in separate areas. Although mainly insectivorous, they also eat fruit, depending on the season. They are migratory birds that breed in the USA and up to northern Canada, but move south in winter to Central or South America. Some vireos are also found in the Caribbean during the breeding season and in winter.

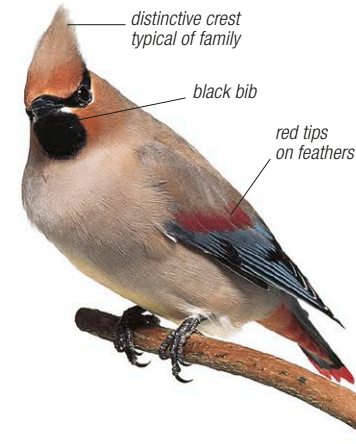
TAWNY-CROWNED GREENLET
Found in the forests of northern South America, Hylophilus ochraceiceps is 4½ in (11.5 cm) long and has a rusty-orange crown.



Family Bombycillidae

Waxwings

Length 6–9 in (15–23 cm)
Species 3



This group consists of 3 waxwings. The 3 waxwings breed across northern Europe, northern Asia, and much of North America, wintering in the south. They are plump, fawn-brown birds with distinctive crests and silky feathers. Two species have the waxy tips to the secondary wing feathers that give the family its name. Sociable birds, waxwings nest in loose colonies, building their home from twigs and grasses in branches. They feed mainly on berries, flocks turning up even in areas where they are not normally seen and rapidly stripping berry bushes.

JAPANESE WAXWING
Bombycilla japonica breeds in the taiga forest of eastern Siberia and winters farther south in Japan and Korea. Unlike the other 2 waxwings, its secondary feathers lack the waxy drops at their tip. This bird is 6½ in (16 cm) long and is a strong flier.

Family Laniidae

True shrikes

Length 6–14 in (15–35 cm)
Species 33



These small- to medium-sized birds are the most predatory of all passerines. All have a hooked bill with a toothlike point in the upper part, and strong legs and sharp claws for holding prey. True shrikes feed on insects, but some are known to augment their diet with lizards, small birds, and rodents. Several



of them create larders, impaling their prey on thorns or barbed wire, which has given rise to the name “butcher birds” for these shrikes. They are birds of open scrub, and some species are very territorial, even in their winter quarters. They frequently perch on top of a bush, scanning the countryside for prey, and flicking their tail up and down and from side to side. True shrikes are widespread throughout Africa, Europe, and Asia, with 2 species occurring in North America. Bush shrikes and helmet shrikes used to be included, but are now classified in a separate family (Malaconotidae). Northern species migrate south in autumn. Shrikes nest in trees or bushes, and the females lay about 2–7 eggs.

SOUTHERN FISCAL
Widespread in Africa, south of the Sahara down to the Cape, in open woodland, parks, and gardens, Lanius collaris raids other birds' nests and eats the nestlings. About 9 in (22 cm) long, it perches on poles and wires, scanning the ground for insects, mice, and small birds. It will attack birds that enter its territory.

Family Picathartidae

Rockfowl

Length 15½–20 in (39–50 cm)
Species 2



Rockfowl are unusual in having bare skin on the head. They are found in damp, upland rain forest in West Africa up to 6,950 ft (2,100 m). They nest in a rock cave in their territory, sticking a mud nest to a rock face, at a height of 6½–13 ft (2–4 m). Here, the female lays 2 blotched, brown and gray eggs.



WHITE-NECKED PICATHARTES
A social bird, Picathartes gymnocephalus is found from Guinea and Sierra Leone eastward to Togo. It is 16 in (40 cm) long, and has a low, croaking call. This bird forages on the ground for insects, frogs, and snails, moving in springy hops.

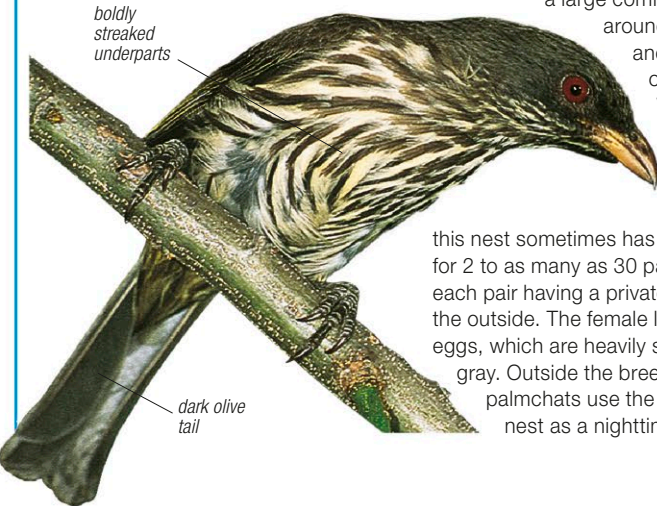
Family Dulidae

Palmchat

Length 7 in (18 cm)
Species 1



The single species in this family, *Dulus dominicus*, is found only in Haiti (including the islet of Gonave) and the



Dominican Republic. Common and conspicuous in these areas, palmchats are often aggressive and very noisy, chattering loudly in chorus. Like waxwings (see left), with which it was formerly grouped, the palmchat is a fruit-eater, often seen in flocks. It never comes to the ground, spending all its time in trees, feeding on berries and flowers with its strong, heavy bill. The palmchat differs from waxwings in its nesting habits: it is known to weave a large communal nest around the trunk and lower fronds of palm trees. Woven from twigs and lined with soft bark and grass, this nest sometimes has compartments for 2 to as many as 30 pairs of birds, each pair having a private entrance from the outside. The female lays 2–4 white eggs, which are heavily spotted with gray. Outside the breeding season, palmchats use the communal nest as a nighttime roost.